DOC 2: Cost of Living & Student Expenses in Ottawa

Overview

This document provides a detailed breakdown of the cost of living for international students in Ottawa. Understanding expenses is essential for financial planning and maintaining legal study permit requirements in Canada.

Ottawa is considered **more affordable than cities like Toronto and Vancouver**, but students must still budget carefully to cover housing, food, transportation, and other daily expenses.

Average Cost of Living in Ottawa

Estimated total living cost for students:

- **8 months (academic year):** ~$24,320
- **Monthly estimate:** ~$3,000

This includes:

- Housing
- Food
- Transportation
- Personal expenses

👉 Costs vary depending on lifestyle, housing choice, and spending habits.

1. Housing Costs (Largest Expense)

Housing is typically the **biggest cost for students in Ottawa**.

Types of Housing

On-Campus Housing

- Provided by universities/colleges
- Convenient and close to classes
- Includes utilities and sometimes meal plans

Estimated cost:

- **$800 – $1,500/month**

Available through:

- University of Ottawa housing
- Carleton University residence
- Algonquin College housing

Off-Campus Housing

- Apartments, shared housing, or rooms
- More independence but requires planning

Estimated cost:

- Shared housing: **$600 – $1,000/month**
- Private apartment: **$1,200 – $2,000+/month**

Housing Resources

- City housing support: https://ottawa.ca/en/living-ottawa/housing
- Student housing platforms: https://www.places4students.com/ https://www.kijiji.ca/
- Facebook market

2. Food & Groceries

Students can choose between cooking or eating out.

Estimated Costs

- Groceries: **$250 – $400/month**
- Eating out occasionally: **$100 – $300/month**

Popular Grocery Stores

- Walmart
- Loblaws
- No Frills

💡 Cooking at home significantly reduces costs.

3. Transportation Costs

Ottawa has a reliable public transit system.

Public Transit

Operated by:

- OC Transpo

Student Costs

- Monthly student pass: **~$120 – $130**

Includes:

- Buses
- O-Train (light rail)

Transportation Resource

https://www.octranspo.com/

4. Health Insurance

Health insurance is **mandatory** for international students.

Options

University/College Health Plans

- Automatically included in tuition (in most cases)

Ontario Health Insurance Plan (OHIP)

- Not all international students qualify

Estimated Cost

- **$600 – $900 per year**

Health Information

https://www.ontario.ca/page/health-insurance

5. Tuition Fees

Tuition varies by institution and program.

Estimated Tuition

- Undergraduate programs: **$31,000+ per year**
- College programs: **$15,000 – $25,000 per year**

Where to Compare Programs

https://www.ontariocolleges.ca/en/international

6. Utilities & Internet

If living off campus, you may need to pay:

- Electricity
- Heating
- Internet

Estimated Cost

- Utilities: **$100 – $150/month**
- Internet: **$50 – $80/month**

7. Phone Plans

Students need a Canadian phone number.

Popular Providers

- Rogers
- Bell
- Fido
- Freedom Mobile

Estimated Cost

- **$40 – $80/month**

8. Personal & Miscellaneous Expenses

Includes:

- Clothing
- Entertainment
- School supplies

- Gym memberships

Estimated Cost

- **$100 – $300/month**

9. Budget Summary (Monthly Estimate)

Expense Category	Estimated Cost
Housing	$600 – $2,000
Food	$300 – $700
Transportation	$120 – $130
Phone	$40 – $80
Utilities/Internet	$100 – $200
Personal Expenses	$100 – $300
Total	**~$1,500 – $3,000+**

Financial Planning Tips

- Create a monthly budget and track spending
- Share housing to reduce costs
- Use student discounts whenever possible
- Cook at home instead of eating out
- Take advantage of free campus services

Important Requirement (IRCC)

The Government of Canada requires students to show proof of funds to cover:

- Tuition
- Living expenses

More details:
https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/study-canada/study-permit.html

Conclusion

Ottawa offers a balance between affordability and quality of life. While costs are lower than other major cities, students must plan carefully to manage expenses and meet immigration requirements.